# A Full Month of Obedience

*A Where Winds Meet fanfiction by Y.*

*Tags: Reader x Uncle Chen - Slow-burn Romance - Slice of Life - Comedy - Wuxia*

*Characters: Uncle Chen (Chen Zixi) x Reader*

*Fandom: Where Winds Meet (Game)*

*Dedicated to Nimm, Prompt Writer par excellence.*

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I really was not counting on my bad luck when I walked into the most pretentious man you could imagine, on my way into the city of Kaifeng on this damned day three weeks ago. And yet, I should have known. I should have known that the sheer rain that came out of the greyest skies imaginable and that had drenched all my clothes, my black mare and my saddle roll, was only the beginning of my misery. I should have known that trying to overtake a dawdling carriage was only the beginning of a series of bad decisions on my part.

The carriage, I will admit, was not the problem. The puddle was the problem. It lay in the road like a small brown lake that had been waiting years for someone foolish enough to cross it at a trot, and my mare, who has never once shown me mercy, obliged. The wave rose beautifully. It hung in the air for one glorious heartbeat, and then it landed on a man standing under the eaves of a roadside shrine, wearing the whitest robe I have ever seen on a living person.

Had. He had been wearing the whitest robe with the softest bamboo leaves woven across his shoulder.

He did not shout. I would have preferred shouting. He looked down at himself, slowly, the way one inspects a wound, and then he looked up at me like someone whose ancestor had just been insulted in public.

“Do you know,…” he said, “…how long it takes to bring a silk to this colour?”

“I could not possibly guess.”, I answered, my mouth faster than my brain. Typical.

“Eleven days. Eleven days of dew, and a breeze from the east, and no one, *no one*, speaking ill of the weather in the same room.” He folded his umbrella, which he had been holding at an angle that suggested he had consulted the rain

before stepping out today. “And you, with that animal, in this, on a day like this. You've ruined it.”

“It is raining,” I said. “It rains on everyone. It rained on me first.”

“It will stop at the hour of the Rooster.”

I looked up. The sky was the colour of wet slate, low and heavy, with no seam of light anywhere in it. Water ran off my hat brim in a steady little curtain. “It will not stop at the hour of the Rooster. It will not stop this week.”

And that, dear reader of my misfortunes, is how it began. No swords, no insulted clans or factions of the Jianghu, just two people standing in the mud and arguing about the sky.

It went on far longer than either of us could defend later on. At some point, he told me my riding posture was an offence to horses, and I told him that a man who owns a robe that white has clearly never done a day of honest work, and he went very quiet first and very pink second, and then said, “Then let us settle it.”

“Settle what?”

“If the rain ends by the hour of the Rooster, you lose. Whoever loses obeys the winner for one month. Every instruction. Without complaint.” He smiled. It was an awful smile, thin and certain. “I am Chen Zixi. Some in this world call me Uncle Chen, which you may absolutely not do, unless you are ready to learn some respect.”

I should have asked how a person could be so sure about the weather. I should have noticed that he had not once looked up at the clouds. Instead I said, “Done,” because I was wet and proud and thoroughly out of sense.

At the hour of the Rooster, the rain stopped. I had always believed that honest rain tapers off. This rain was not honest. It simply stopped. A pale thread of light broke through the west, and the whole road turned briefly the colour of honey, steaming gently, every wet tile and eave and drowned leaf giving back one small bright drop, and Chen Zixi, without a word, shook out his ruined sleeve and held out one hand, palm up, as though waiting for his change.

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The first week, he ruined me.

His garden is behind a gate that sticks, at the end of a lane that smells of damp stone and persimmons, and it is, I will say it plainly, a beautiful garden. It is also a tyrant of the plant realm. On the very first morning, Uncle Chen walked me out among the rocks, the pear tree and the sleeping bamboo and told me that the garden's *qi* had shifted overnight, that the stone lantern was now facing a hostile wind, and that the whole arrangement needed to be moved a hand's breadth to the north.

I moved it. It weighed as much as a small ox.

The next morning the *qi* had shifted again. The lantern went back. The bench went east. A pot of chrysanthemums that I had carried across the garden with real tenderness was returned to its original place with a sniff, and I stood there with soil to my elbows, listening to the old man sip his tea on the veranda like a magistrate presiding over a very small, very silly trial.

"Feng shui," he said, "is a living thing. You cannot simply arrange it once and expect it to forgive you."

"Then perhaps it should be less sensitive."

"Perhaps *you* should be more flexible. Again, please. The pear tree is looking at the lantern with suspicion."

The tea was worse. There was a basket in his storeroom the size of a cartwheel, heaped with fresh leaves that smelled of green rain and cut grass, and on the third day he told me to sort them. By age, naturally. Then by which side of the hill they had grown on. Then by the order in which the morning light had touched them, which, he informed me with great gravity, *changes the taste*, and which I was apparently meant to deduce from the leaves themselves. Obviously.

"How would I possibly know that?"

"You would if you listened to them."

"Leaves do not talk."

"Not to you, clearly." said Uncle Chen, and handed me a cup of the finished tea from yesterday's sorting, and it was, to my growing irritation, the best tea I have ever tasted. It was the kind of tea that makes your shoulders sag and forget themselves. I drank it in silence and hated him quietly, thoroughly, with my whole heart.

I plotted against him, of course. I composed whole speeches in the bath. I imagined leaving at dawn with the mare, and the lantern still facing the wrong wind, and a note on the veranda that said only: *the pear tree sends its regards*. But the wager was the wager, and I have never in my life walked away from a bet, even when the bet had walked all over me.

Somewhere in the second week, something shifted, and I want to be exact about how, because I did not notice it happening until the end of the week. The tasks stopped being mine alone and his over present man servant was suddenly occupied elsewhere.

First it was the market. “You will carry,” he said, “and I will choose,” and so I followed him through the morning crowd of Kaifeng with a basket on each arm while he interrogated a fishmonger about the moon, and a woman selling dried ginger about her mother, and an entire stall of pickled radishes about, as far as I could tell, their moral character. He haggled like a general and paid like a saint. He pressed a copper into the hand of a child with a runny nose and then complained about the child’s manners for the full length of the street.

Then it was the lectures. Every afternoon, whatever the weather, I was to sit on the veranda cushion beside him while he explained the way a cup should be held (as one holds a sleeping bird), the way water should be poured (as one tells a hard truth: from a height, but not in anger), and the way a person should enter a room. I contradicted him daily. He enjoyed it more than I did, I am nearly sure; he would lean back with his eyes half closed and say, “Yes, yes, very good, now argue the other side,” as if my objections were a kind of snack.

At first I thought that he just loved to hear himself talk and needed an audience. But clearly, he just enjoyed the contradiction.

And then came the training. I had not told him I could fight or that I was a martial artist wanderer without a home. I had not needed to; he had looked at me on the road, in the rain, in all my muddy glory, and he had known. At dawn on the eleventh day he walked me out into the first frost, among the bamboo, where the whole garden was breathing white, and told me to hold horse stance until the sun cleared the wall.

I held it. My thighs burned. My breath hung in the air in small, indignant clouds. And Uncle Chen walked slowly round me, a cup in his hand, correcting my shoulders with the tip of one finger, my wrist with the edge of his sleeve, saying nothing at all for so long that I forgot to be angry and just listened, to the dripping bamboo, to a wren somewhere in the pear tree, to the first thin light coming up behind the roofs like milk poured into water.

“Better,” he said.

It was the first kind word he had spoken to me in eleven days. I nearly fell over from shock.

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That was three weeks ago. Today is the thirtieth day, and I do not know what to do with my hands.

I woke before the light. The mist had come down in the night, and when I stepped onto the veranda the garden was simply gone: no bamboo, no lantern, no wall, only a soft white nothing that tasted of cold stone and ripe persimmon. I could barely make out the pear tree, ten paces away.

But the world was still there. It spoke to me out of the whiteness, piece by piece. The night guardian calling the hour somewhere beyond wall. A rooster in the next lane, indignant. The small tin clink of a donkey’s bell, the creak of a water carrier’s yoke, and under all of it the slow drip of the night’s rain falling from the bamboo, from the tiles, from every bare bough. Each drop hung a moment on the tip of a leaf, trembling, before it let go.

The year is going out in something paler than gold now, a milky light, the warmth of the season withdrawn from the branches and into the walls, the kitchen, the bones. The persimmons hang on the bare boughs like small lanterns lit for nobody, the last bright thing in the garden. And I am standing here, in all that suspended, hidden life and I realise that it is all still here. I simply had not been looking.

I got up before him, this morning. I do that now. I swept the veranda, and I rearranged the garden, and I did not complain, and I stood for a long moment with the stone lantern in my arms, facing it toward the east, then the north, then the east again, and I realised that I had stopped asking whether the *qi* had really shifted. I could feel it. Not the *qi*, perhaps. But the shape of the morning, the way the whole garden leans toward some invisible centre when the sun first catches the wall. The man is not a fraud. That is the unbearable thing. He is simply right in ways I had not learned to see. Yet.

Thirty days. That was the bargain, and it ends tonight.

I had imagined this day so many times, in the first week, with such savage pleasure. I would bow, very low, with perfect irony. I would say, *it has been an*

*education*, and ride out through that sticking gate with my mare, who has never once shown me mercy, and I would not look back.

I had not imagined that I would stand here with a lantern in my arms, unable to put it down.

I am a person who leaves. I know this about myself the way I know the weight of my own saddle. Roads, inns, other people's weather, never staying long enough for a place to learn the sound of my footsteps. It has always seemed to me a kind of freedom. But there is a cup in the kitchen that I have used for four weeks, with a small chip on the rim, and it is the one he hands me without looking, because he knows. There is a cushion on the veranda that has a hollow in it now, the shape of someone who sits too still when he lectures. There is a place at the table, set each evening without comment, and I never once thought to ask why there were always two bowls.

He has not said anything. That is what I keep circling, like a small animal around a fire it has been told is dangerous. All week he has said nothing about the end of the month. No speech, no hint, not even one of his dry little reminders that a wager is a wager and that a person of honour keeps count. He has simply carried on, complaining about the east wind and my posture, and the way the pear tree sulks, as if the thirty-first day were merely another morning, and tomorrow would arrive with its own list of impossible tasks.

And I want it to. That is the whole truth of it. I want him to look at the sky tomorrow and declare that the *qi* has shifted again, and send me out in the cold to carry a lantern the width of an ox, and I want to argue, and I want him to say *now argue the other side*, and I want, absurdly, with my whole chest, for none of this to be over.

The sun is going down behind the roofs. The light comes slanting through the bamboo the colour of weak tea, and somewhere a bell and a yell is telling the hour, and I am still standing here, a fool in the garden, with soil to my elbows and no wager left to hide behind.

"You have been holding that lantern for a quarter of an hour," says Uncle Chen, from the veranda.

I do not turn around. I do not trust my face.

"It looks well there," he adds, after a while, and I hear the small clink of a second cup being set down beside his own. "The east. Mm. The pear tree approves."

He does not say *you may go*. He does not say anything else at all. The steam rises from the two cups in the dusk, thin and white as a breath held, and I stand there, in the dying gold, and know that if I put the lantern down I will have to decide, and that I have never in my life been so afraid of a stone object.

So I hold it a little longer.

The mist burned off hours ago, and the garden has come back, every stone and bough exactly where it always was. It was there all along. It only needed me to stop, and look.

Still here, says the lantern, cold and heavy against my chest.

Still here, says the steam from two cups.

Still here. The whole quiet lane, waiting, for me to step over the threshold of that sticking gate in one direction or the other. And neither of my feet, I find, has any interest in the road, or the Jianghu.